

freely and fearlessly—and I am speaking of big decisions.

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You did an interesting thing on seeking talent by reaching out to the FMCG sector...

That was actually a learning from my JV partners. We had partnerships with AT&T [and] Siemens, to name a few. When I visited their headquarters, I

talented professionals took precedence.

The thinking was that telecom companies need an engineering mindset and only technical people can run it. The truth is you need marketers and people who understand brand, customers, and distribution. We changed the game and looked at FMCG and now it has become a lexicon with everyone doing it. We brought people

a combination of Unilever [and] Bharti, where you get the experience of working for an MNC and [also at] an entrepreneurial [company].

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You did move into other businesses as well...

I would say the idea at that point in time (about 14-15 years ago) was for Bharti to be one of the most transformational conglomerates creating a positive impact. There was a JV with AXA for life and general insurance, with Del Monte for a food and beverage business, fruits and vegetables with the Rothschilds [with ElRo Holdings, an investment arm of the family], plus a real estate business. But the fact is we were almost always caught up with a lot of storms in our core business and that did not allow us enough time and attention for other things. The businesses did make some money but could not scale up to the level that we've been able to do with telecom. Unlike many other companies, we don't do everything from Airtel and that includes insurance, food, and real estate. They were separate verticals within the Bharti ecosystem. But I would say, they didn't go to plan and there are no regrets.

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Tell us about the Africa experience...

It really comes down to being a restless

organisation and people wanting to do more. We were debt-free in 2009-10 and making enough returns on capital. The question was, 'Where do you go from there?' Our shareholders were always saying, 'grow, grow, grow' and probably you could have grown a little bit faster in India, especially with more fibre or more fixed lines. But everybody felt that we should look at opportunities in the mobility space, where the future lay.

We looked at the US and Europe, but we then said that we are good with these emerging markets where ARPUs [average revenue per user] are low... Africa became the [opportunity] and we tried [with] MTN twice before we got the opportunity with Zain, who were ready to sell out. We went into difficulties immediately after buying it because for the first two years we mindlessly built the network like in India, thinking customers will come. That didn't happen and the market was not as elastic as we thought [it is] in India. I would say [the first] four to five years were very tough and there was a feeling of regret that we rushed into it too fast. It was going across a continent into 16 countries (at that time) in one go. MNCs become what they are over a 100 years, and here we just woke up to 16 new markets—so probably we had some indigestion. **BT**

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used to be amazed at how nobody knew each other. There were thousands of people, and the senior management were in hundreds. It was an indication of how empowered [they were], and these are not family-led companies. I always had a fascination to create a western model-based company in India. Once that was clear,

from Hindustan Unilever and told them Airtel was like an MNC—much more empowering and less bureaucratic than Unilever. Today, we have people who spent time in HUL, Airtel and [were] poached by industry. The CEO of Domino's [India] is from Airtel, and so are the CTOs of Jio and Vodafone Idea. We became